

HISTORICAL CONTEXTS FOR THE MERCHANT OF VENICE

1. The Idea of Venice in Shakespeare's England

It's unlikely that Shakespeare ever visited Venice, but he was sufficiently fascinated by its myths and history to set two of his greatest plays there, *The Merchant of Venice* and *Othello*. The Venetian Republic was renowned in Shakespeare's day for its political independence, its relaxed sexual morals and love of pleasure, its tolerance of different nationalities and religions, and most of all its great wealth.

Shakespeare could have learned a great deal about Venice and its Jewish community from travelers and published travel accounts. One of the earliest is that of William Thomas, *The History of Italy* (London, 1549), who describes Jewish usury—taking interest at fifteen percent—a rate that enriches both the authorities and the Jews:

It is almost incredible what gain the Venetians receive by the usury of the Jews, both privately and in common. For in every city the Jews keep open shops of usury, taking gages of ordinary for fifteen in the hundred by the year, and if at the year's end the gage be not redeemed it is forfeet, or at the least done away to a great disadvantage, by reason whereof the Jews are out of measure wealthy in those parts.

Another early visitor was Laurence Aldersey, whose "Account of Venice" provides insight into the customs of the Jews. It was written in 1581 and printed in Richard Hakluyt's *Principal Navigations, Voyages, Traffiques, and Discoveries of the English Nation* (3 volumes, London 1598-1600).

The number of Jews is there thought to be 1,000, who dwell in a certain place of the city and have also a place to which they resort to pray, which is called the Jews' Synagogue. They all and their offspring use to wear red caps (for so they are commanded) because there they may be known from other men. For my further knowledge of these people, I went into their synagogue upon a Saturday, which is their Sabbath day, and I found them in their service or prayers, very devout. They receive the Five Books of Moses and honor them by carrying them about their church, as the papists do their cross. Their synagogue is in form round and the people sit around it, and in the midst there is a place for him

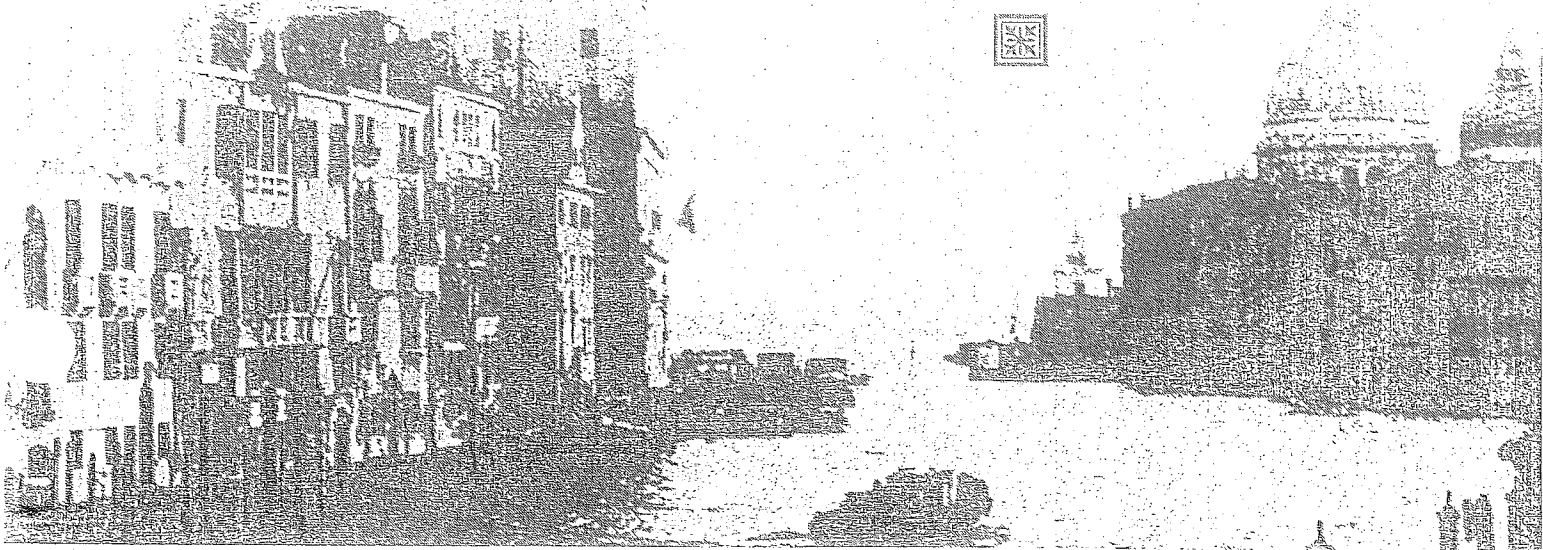
that reads to the rest. As for their apparel, all of them wear a large white lawn over their garments which reaches from their head down to the ground. The psalms they sing as we do, having no image nor using any manner of idolatry. Their error is that they believe not in Christ, nor yet receive the New Testament.

An even more vivid contemporary account of Venetian Jewry is offered by Thomas Coryate, in his travel narrative *Coryat's Crudities* (London, 1611):

I was at a place where the whole fraternity of the Jews dwelleth together, which is called the ghetto, being an island: for it is enclosed round about with water. It is thought there are of them in all betwixt five and six thousand. They are distinguished and discerned from the Christians by the habits on their heads; for some of them do wear hats and those red. . . . They have divers synagogues in their ghetto, at the least seven, where all of them, both men, women, and children, do meet together upon their Sabbath, which is Saturday, to the end to do their devotion and to serve God in their kind . . .

In the room where they celebrate their divine service, no women sit but have a loft or gallery proper to themselves only, where I saw many Jewish women, whereof some were as beautiful as I ever saw, and so gorgeous in their apparel, jewels, and chains of gold, and rings adorned with precious stones, that some of our English countesses do scarce exceed them . . . They are very religious in two things only, and no more, in that they worship no images, and that they keep their Sabbath so strictly that upon that day they will neither buy nor sell, nor do any secular, profane, or irreligious exercise (I would to God our Christians would imitate the Jews herein), no, not so much as dress their victuals, which is always done the day before, but dedicate themselves to the strict worship of God. . . .

Truly, it is a most lamentable case for a Christian to consider the damnable estate of these miserable Jews, in that they reject the true Messiah and Savior of their souls, hoping to be saved rather by the observation of these Mosaical ceremonies (the date whereof was fully expired at Christ's incarnation) than by the merits of the Savior of the world, without whom all mankind shall perish. And as pitiful as it is to see that few of them living in Italy are converted to the Christian religion. For this I understand is the main impediment to their conversion. All their goods are confiscated as soon as they embrace Christianity.



THE VENETIAN GHETTO

Because of their central role in economic exchange—in foreign trade, loans to the state, and small-scale money-lending—Jews were seen in late medieval and early modern Europe as a necessary evil; they could neither be tolerated nor expelled. Jews had been lending money to Venice to fight its wars since the late fourteenth century. Venetian authorities, like others in Europe, felt uneasy about the close cohabitation of Christians and Jews, so they passed laws forbidding sexual relations between them.

The origins of the Venetian Ghetto can be traced back to the Fourth Lateran Council of 1215, when Pope Innocent III decreed that Jews should be forbidden from holding public office, should have clothing that distinguished them from Christians, and should not appear in public during Easter week. It was the responsibility of Christian magistrates to restrict Jewish economic activity. Segregation was seen as a simple way of enforcing these laws in Venice and elsewhere (Jews had been living in restricted quarters in cities like Prague since the late thirteenth century). Jews had been permitted to live in Venice in 1509, and soon secured the right to practice money-lending in return for financial payments to the state. They were tolerated as a source of revenue for the government and as providers of cheap credit for poor Christians. Unlike what we find in Shakespeare's play, Venetian Jews were forbidden to make large-scale commercial loans.

In 1516, after rejecting the idea of relegating the Jews to a small island called Giudecca, the Venetian authorities designated an area called the *ghetto nuovo*, or "new foundry," named after the copper

and bronze foundry there, as the locale where all Jews were required to relocate and to live in rented quarters. This is the origin of the now widespread use of the term "ghetto." High walls sealed off access and heavy wooden gates, guarded by Christians, were opened at sunrise and locked at sunset. At its peak, several thousand Jews lived in the Ghetto and a thriving community flourished.

Anti-Jewish actions intensified in the sixteenth-century Catholic Europe, part of a larger Counter-Reformation reaction by the Church. Copies of the Talmud were burned in 1553 and Jews who had converted to Christianity, and whose conversion was suspect, were persecuted. In 1555 Pope Paul IV declared, "Jews were condemned to live in a quarter set apart from the Christians." They also had to wear distinctive garb and were no longer allowed to own real estate. The Venetian Ghetto served as a model for other Italian cities. In the wake of Pope Paul IV's decree, similar restrictions were imposed on Jewish communities in Rome, Siena, Florence, Verona, Padua, and elsewhere in Italy.

Not until 1797, two hundred and eighty years after they had first swung shut on the Jews within, would the wooden gates of the Venetian ghetto be torn down and burned. The gateless Ghetto still stands, a living memorial to the story of Jews in early modern Europe.



CONTEXT: USURY AND THE JEWS

he bitter conflict between Antonio and Shylock is rooted in their different approaches to money-lending. Shylock hates Antonio because "He lends out money gratis and brings down / The rate of usance here with us in Venice" (1.3.34-35). Shylock knows that he is hated in turn by Antonio and other Christians because he makes an ample living through the practice of usury. He says of Antonio,

He hates our sacred nation, and he rails,
Even there where merchants most do congregate,
On me, my bargains, and my well-won thrift,
Which he calls interest.
Cursed be my tribe
If I forgive him! (1.3.38-42)

Antonio says, "I oft delivered from his forfeitures / Many that have at times made moan to me" (3.3.22-23). Antonio's refusal to take interest from borrowers is seen in the context of the play as Christian generosity, while Shylock is positioned as a bloodthirsty fiend. However, Christian usury had become business as usual by the time the play was written.

Debates over usury in late medieval and early modern Europe coincided with, and were prompted by, the rise of the banking industry, the discovery of the new world and the growth of overseas markets and trade, all of which depended on money lent at interest. For without loans at interest, trade and exploration were badly impeded. There was general agreement that usury was both wrong and necessary, and had to be regulated. The debates turned on a number of complex questions: Was all money-lending at interest forbidden, as St. Thomas Aquinas had argued, or was it only wrong to lend at exorbitant rates? Did usury depend upon intent? Did it

depend upon risk? Was it permissible to charge interest to the rich, though not to the poor?

Shakespeare's play was written in the midst of debates in England over usury, and the period witnessed a number of important pamphlets on this subject, such as *The Death of Usury* (London, 1594) and *Money Monger, Or the Usurers Almanacke* (London, 1626). After the Act Against Usury passed in 1571, lending at ten percent interest was tolerated and by 1624, the House of Commons struck out of the usury statute the words "that all usury was against the law of God."

Jewish usury was also likened to prostitution, another distasteful, illicit, but seemingly necessary social evil: Samuel Purchas, in *Purchas His Pilgrimage* (London, 1617), writes that the "bestly trade of courtesans and cruel trade of Jews is suffered for gain" in Italy; both "suck from the meanest to be squeezed by the greatest. . . . So well is the rule of Paul observed . . . not to be a lover of filthy lucre, from filthy stews, from filthy Jews." For Jews, however, usury was freely permitted on loans to non-Jews (see Deuteronomy below).

The topic of usury was not merely an academic one for Shakespeare; his own father was charged and fined for lending money at excessive interest—charging twenty pounds interest on loans of eighty and a hundred pounds—and he was fined forty shillings in one of these cases.

The readings that follow offer the much-debated positions in the Bible, which are followed by the pros and cons of usury as set out by Francis Bacon in his *Essays*.

EXODUS 22:25

If thou lend money to my people, that is, to the poor with thee, thou shalt not be as an usurer unto him: ye shall not oppress him with usury.

LEVITICUS 25:35-37

Moreover, if thy brother be impoverished and fallen into decay with thee, thou shalt relieve him and as a stranger and a sojourner, so shall he live with thee. Thou shalt take no usury of him nor vantage, but thou shalt fear thy god, that thy brother may live with thee. Thou shalt not give him thy money to usury, nor lend him thy vituals for increase.

DEUTERONOMY 23:19-20

Thou shalt not give to usury to thy brother, as usury of money, usury of meat, usury of anything that is put to usury. Unto a stranger thou mayest lend upon usury, but thou shalt not lend upon usury unto thy brother, that the Lord God may bless thee in all that thou setteth thine hand to, in the land whither thou goest to possess it.

LUKE 6:30-31

Give to every man that asketh of thee; and of him that taketh away thy goods, ask them not again. And as ye would that men should do to you, so do ye to them likewise.

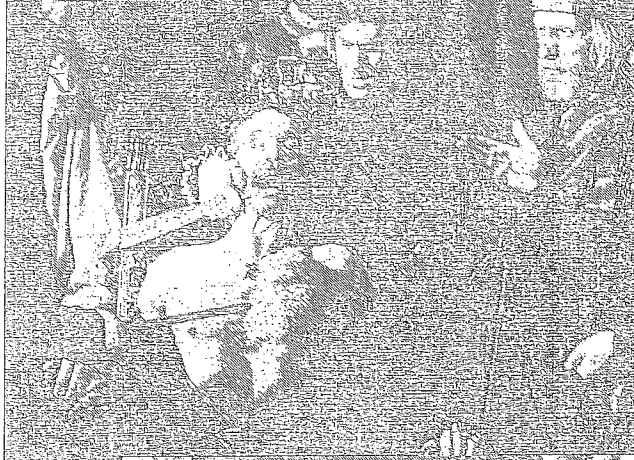
[all quotations are from the Geneva Bible (London, 1560)]



SHAKESPEARE'S SOURCES

Shakespeare combined two sources in creating *The Merchant of Venice*, one for the flesh-bond story, the other for the caskets scenes. The story of the pound of flesh most immediately derives from Giovanni Fiorentino's collection *Il Pecorone* [*The Simpleton*], published in Italy in 1558. Many of its plot elements are familiar to those who know Shakespeare's story. A young Venetian man pursues a mysterious, intelligent, and beautiful woman in Belmonte, who has offered herself and her possessions to the first man who can "possess" her. The young man, Giannetto, has been adopted by Ansaldo, a rich man who gives him the wealth and ship he needs to make his suit to the lady. He sails to the island and is feasted by the lady, who then invites him to take a drink before going to bed with her. The drink is drugged, and he falls asleep immediately. On his second attempt events follow the same pattern. Giannetto returns to Ansaldo, who has now invested much of his wealth in Giannetto's suits, and for the third try Ansaldo borrows the money from a Jewish money-lender. Giannetto goes to the island and succeeds the third time (with help from the lady's servant), but forgets to repay Ansaldo's bond on time. The benefactor now owes the Jew a pound of flesh. The heroine, dressed as a lawyer, saves the day, triumphing over the Jew by pointing out that in cutting that pound he is forbidden to shed a drop of blood. The lawyer also persuades Giannetto to give her a ring his lady had given him, and the lady presents him with the ring when he returns to Belmonte. Ansaldo returns to Belmonte with Giannetto, and marries the lady's servant, who had appeared in the courtroom disguised as the lawyer's clerk. The flesh-bond story at the heart of this tale is an old one and was found in a variety of contemporary versions, including Alexander Silvayn's *The Orator*—"Of a Jew, who would for his debt have a pound of the flesh of a Christian"—which had just been translated into English.

In *Il Pecorone* the heroine could only be won by a man who succeeded in spending a night with her, but she used drugged wine to fend off all wooers,



including the hero (until, on his third attempt, he was warned not to drink the wine). Shakespeare rejected this bed trick, with its roots in the story of Odysseus and Circe, in favor of the more complex casket story, which he adapted from Richard Robinson's English translation of the *Gesta Romanorum*. In this source it is a princess who successfully chooses between the gold, silver, and lead caskets in order to marry an emperor's son.

The two strands of the plot have deep anthropological and psychological dimensions, which lend a good deal of complexity to the play. Sigmund Freud seized upon the casket scenes as an example of the symbolic overcoming of death and the death wish: "In this way," Freud writes, "man overcomes death, which he has recognized intellectually. No greater triumph of wish-fulfillment is conceivable" (*The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, trans. James Strachey [London, 1958], vol. 12, pp. 291-301,

And others have seen in the threatened cut of a pound of a Christian's flesh a threat of circumcision or castration—underscored by the Jew's lines in Silvayn's *The Orator* about cutting the Christian's "privy members." (It's worth noting that not until Act 4 do we learn that the site of Shylock's cut will be from near Antonio's heart, where, as St. Paul writes in the New Testament, Christians are symbolically circumcised).

All this is to suggest that the plot elements are ancient and richly resonant, and reinforce the play's fascination with desire, conversion, and wish fulfillment.

